

OpenMRS 2012: A Meet that Rocked!



"All of us in Google's Open Source Programs Office are very pleased to see how many exceptional contributors to OpenMRS have started working with this outstanding humanitarian FLOSS project through their work with Google Summer of Code."

—Cat Allman (Co-organiser
Science Foo Camp, Open
Source Programs at Google)

This year's OpenMRS Implementers Meeting was indeed a rocking affair. It was held at the International Institute of Rural Reconstruction in Silang, Philippines from October 9-12, 2012. More than 100 people from over 21 countries participated in the event, including attendees from the United States, Kenya, India, Sri Lanka, Pakistan and other countries. Google and ThoughtWorks were the sponsors for this year's event.

The annual Implementers Meeting began in 2006 as a way to bring members of the community together to collaborate, share implementation experiences, and find ways to improve OpenMRS. This meeting provides an opportunity for developers to collaborate and improve their technical skills in OpenMRS, for implementers to share their best practices from implementations, and for users to propose and prioritise their top features in future releases of the software. As was introduced last year, the 2012 Implementers Meeting also included visits to OpenMRS implementation sites.

The meeting started with opening remarks from OpenMRS co-founder Paul Biondich, followed by welcome addresses from the Hon Juanito Victor C. Remulla, Governor of Cavite, and Dr Portia Fernandez-Marcelo, director of the National Telehealth Centre. The un-conference format allows people to follow the talks and discussions of their own choice.

A lot of parallel talks were organised on Day 1. First, Paul Biondich presented the 'State of OpenMRS', and Bill Lober discussed the architecture and interoperability of OpenMRS. Later, Roger Friedman discussed requirements for hospital systems. Afterwards, a group of implementers with varied experiences did a short brainstorming session led by Dawn Smith, Lauren Stanisic and James Arbaugh. This was followed by a session by Tobin Greensweig, who explained issues around point-of-care OpenMRS use. Then Ellen Ball and Viet Long Pham discussed upgrades and

data exchanges. Day 1 ended with several 'birds of a feather' sessions that included discussions about things like promoting OpenMRS service providers, and a Google Summer of Code (GSoC) discussion session.

Day 2 started with a discussion on biometrics in OpenMRS, presented by Shaun Grannis, followed by data migration from .NET systems into OpenMRS, which was presented by Titi Tsholofelo. Afterwards Darius Jazayeri led an interactive session on how to use OpenMRS to build an EMR application. The session on the 'OpenMRS Reporting module' was led by Mike Seaton.

On Day 2's 'birds of a feather sessions', there were discussions about large-scale OpenMRS deployments, pharmacy modules, Kenya OpenMRS distributions, MDR-TB module experiences and future needs, inventory management with the Open Boxes system, and a discussion about the OpenMRS learning curve.

On Day 3, there were visits to the various clinics in which the OpenMRS-powered distribution CHITS system was in production. That was followed by a remarkable session by OpenMRS co-founder Burke Mamlin on the future roadmap for OpenMRS.

Day 4, the last day of the meet, started with a 'Site Visit Q&A Forum' presented by Burke Mamlin and local implementers. This was followed by sessions on mobile technology in OpenMRS by Nicholas Wilkie, multiple applications at a single facility by Mwatha Bwanali, and registration modules with Tobin Greensweig. The meet ended with a review of the 2012 meeting and a discussion on the future prospects of the community. 

References

- [1] OpenMRS: <http://openmrs.org/>
- [2] Event: <http://events.openmrs.org/>
- [3] Event coverage: <http://lanayrd.com/2012/omrs12/>
- [4] Notes: <http://lanayrd.com/2012/omrs12/notes/>
- [5] CHITS: <http://chits.ph/>